D’var Torah on Parshas Vayetzei: When Speech Builds and Listening Unites

Foundational Themes

Parshas Vayetzei is a parsha of transition. The Torah opens, "ויצא יעקב מבאר שבע וילך חרנה" (Bereishis 28:10), Yaakov leaves Be’er Sheva and walks toward Charan, a movement not only of place but of identity. Yaakov Avinu leaves his parents’ home, leaves safety, and steps into exile. This is where the Jewish people are first formed not in holiness, not in comfort, but inside complexity.

But beneath the storyline of journeys, marriages, and rivalries lies a deeper theme that runs through the parsha: the power of letters, words, speaking, listening and communicating.

And not just communication, but relationship. Not just words, but unity. Not just expression, but connection.

The Power of Conversation

Earlier this week, I was zocheh to have a long conversation with one of my mashpi’im about the value of conversation and the importance of words. We spoke about something simple yet profound.

When one person speaks continuously and never leaves space for the other to respond, even without bad intention, the result can become harmful. Real dialogue requires exchange. One speaks, one listens, and then they trade places. This back and forth is not just conversation, it is the start and foundation of building and maintaining relationships.

Speech without space can collapse connection. Listening without voice can erase identity.

Health lives in balance. And it was such perfect timing to have that conversation during this week’s Parsha Vayetzei.

And that is at least one of the lessons which Parshas Vayetzei shows us.

Leaving and Being Felt

When Yaakov leaves Be’er Sheva, Chazal teach that the city feels his absence, learned from the extra wording of "ויצא יעקב מבאר שבע" (Bereishis 28:10), that the Torah highlights his departure because it mattered. There is a difference between someone whose departure brings relief and someone whose departure leaves emptiness.

There are people who leave, and things breathe easier.
There are people who leave, and the room goes quiet.

Yaakov was the second kind.

The Torah teaches us something powerful here: it is not only who you are when you arrive that matters, it is who you are when you are there and the impact felt when you leave. Or as I was tought regarding a teaching of the Baal Shem Tov taught, that we should periodically ask ourselves, "What would people say at your funeral?" or “What would I want people to say about me at my funeral?”

The Stones and the Letters

Then comes the night and Yaakov lies down.

The Torah says, "ויקח מאבני המקום" (Bereishis 28:11), he took from the stones of the place and lay down. Later, after the dream, the Torah says, "ויקח את האבן" (Bereishis 28:18), he took the stone, in the singular.

Rashi (Bereishis 28:11) describes the scene with beautiful imagery:

Hebrew:
התחילו מריבות זו עם זו, זאת אומרת עלי יניח צדיק את ראשו, וזאת אומרת עלי יניח, מיד עשאן הקדוש ברוך " הוא אבן אחת"

English:
"The stones began arguing with one another. Each one said, 'Let the righteous one rest his head upon me.' Immediately, Hashem made them into one stone, turning rivalry into unity."

Kabbalah and Chassidus take this further.

The Alter Rebbe in a maamar on the power of speech and malchus for this week’s parsha brings a teaching from Sefer Yetzirah (Perek 4:12):

שתי אבנים בונות שתי בתים.
שלש אבנים בונות שש בתים.
ארבע אבנים עשרים וארבעה בתים

Two stones build two houses.
Three stones build six houses.
Four stones build twenty four houses.

The stones are not just stones. They are letters. When you have two letters, you have two combinations. When you have three letters, the possible words increase.

Letters combine, words form and reality multiplies. The more letters there are, the more combinations are possible which bring more words, more speech and the ability to build more worlds.

But Yaakov's stones move in the opposite direction.

Not from one to many, from many to one. Not multiplication but rather unification.

The message is striking. Words can build worlds but they can also fracture them. When speech is fragmented, relationships crumble. When speech is unified, holiness enters. This doesn't mean that all the speech needs to be the same, it means that there is space for all the speech to exist in the same space in a respectful way.

Three Styles of Speech

Now compare Yaakov to his father and grandfather.

Avraham spoke outward. He challenged the world. He argued with Hashem (for good things). He brought strangers into his tent and pulled ideas into the light.

Yitzchak spoke inward. He was formed through silence. The Akeidah is quiet. His tefillah is private. He does not fight reality, he accepts it.

And Yaakov? Yaakov speaks between people. He negotiates. He explains. He listens. He creates relationships through conversation.

The Art of Listening

Yaakov's greatness is not only in how he speaks, but in how he listens.

He listens to Rivkah when she tells him to take the brachah (Bereishis 27:8–10) and when she sends him to her family in Charan (Bereishis 27:43). He listens to Rachel and Leah before leaving Lavan, and only moves after hearing them (Bereishis 31:4–16). He listens to Yosef's dreams and "ואביו שמר את הדבר" (Bereishis 37:11), he guarded the matter. He listens to Lavan, even when wronged, until there comes a moment when truth must finally speak.

And later, standing before Paroh (Bereishis 47:8–9),, the most powerful man on earth, Paroh asks him a simple question:

"How many are the days of your life?"

Yaakov gives no performance. No flattery. No politics.

He answers from truth, "מעט ורעים היו ימי שני חיי" (Bereishis 47:9).

“My life was hard.”
“Few were my days.”
“I did not reach my fathers.”

That is a man who has listened to his own story.

From Noise to Meaning

Avraham changed the world with speech.
Yitzchak deepened the soul with silence.
Yaakov built a nation through conversation.

He teaches us that holiness does not live in volume or withdrawal. It lives in relationship: listening with intention, what Rabbi Gerzi calls "Baal Shem Tov listening," speaking with care, and answering with honesty. It lives in relationship. Listening with intention as Rabbi Gerzi call this "Baal Shem Tov listening". From there speaking with care and answering with honesty.

Shabbos as a Return to Dialogue

Shabbos invites us into what Yaakov mastered.

We turn off the noise. We put down distance. We undo fracture.

We speak. We listen. We reconnect.

Not as performers. Not as commentators. As people.

As family. As Jews.

Reflection and Growth

This week, ask yourself:

- Am I speaking for just my own needs or speaking to build more relationship with those I am speaking with?
- Am I listening in order to answer, or listening in order to receive?
- Do my words build space, or do they take it?
- Am I arguing to win, or communicating to connect?

Closing Thought

Many letters can build many worlds.
But unity builds eternity.